It’s hard to tell exactly what brings a successful group together. There’s the obvious: good players, good coaching, good management.

To turn individuals into a team, though, something else needs to happen, especially at international level where the players come from clubs all over the country. Being together, playing together and winning and losing games together all make a difference. An international coach has to try and make it possible for a side to develop despite injuries, dips in club form and how little time the England team has together apart from the few days before matches. The players have done their bit and, like I’ve said, maybe the age of the squad helped. But Sven deserves some of the credit, at least, for creating a better team spirit than I can remember us ever having had with England before.

There have been times in the past when we’d meet up and you knew who would be with who straight away. Cliques were in place along the lines of the senior and younger players or according to rivalries between clubs. It’s a natural thing to stick with your mates. We were as bad as anybody: the United lads used to be famous for keeping to ourselves. So much of that has changed now. I’d say there’s a real bond, a real mutual respect, amongst the current England squad and that makes a difference when we go out and play. We could all feel it starting to happen within months of Sven taking charge. The new manager treated us like grown ups, gave us respect and responsibility and demanded the same in return.

I remember the 4–0 exhibition win against Mexico at Pride Park, in between qualifying games in the Spring of 2001. There was a moment in that game that summed up the new spirit in the England camp. Quite early on, one of the Mexican defenders barged into me from behind. It wasn’t too serious: I just limped away and got on with it. But within about a minute, Stevie Gerrard had gone flying into this same player—legally, he played the ball first—and left him rolling around on the floor. Looking after your mates: it’s an attitude I knew well enough from United. It’s an attitude you’ll see in every team that wins games and trophies.

We beat Greece in Athens and Albania in Tirana, which at least made us favorites to finish second and qualify for a play-off to reach the World Cup Finals the following summer. To win the group and go through to Japan and South Korea automatically, we knew we’d have to win in Munich. And, even though things had been going well under Sven, I don’t think there were too many people who fancied our chances of doing that. Nobody beats the Germans in Germany, do they? For once, expectations weren’t too high, so that took some of the pressure off us. We didn’t have to worry too much about